

Attitudes of Brazilian Voters on the United States and China

How Partisanship and Presidential Approval Shape View of Foreign Policy

Gustavo Marangoni

Overview

- During Lula Inácio da Silva's administration, Brazil has deepened political and economic relationships with China, especially through the BRICS forum.
- This is a contrast from Jair Bolsonaro's administration, who was openly allied to the United States and the Trump administration.
- Given the upcoming **October presidential elections** and that both presidents represent different political parties and ideologies in Brazil, this study uses the Latinobarómetro to answer the question:

To what extent does partisanship and presidential approval shape the view of the Brazilian population towards Foreign Policy, specifically in attitudes towards United States and China?

Data and Methodology

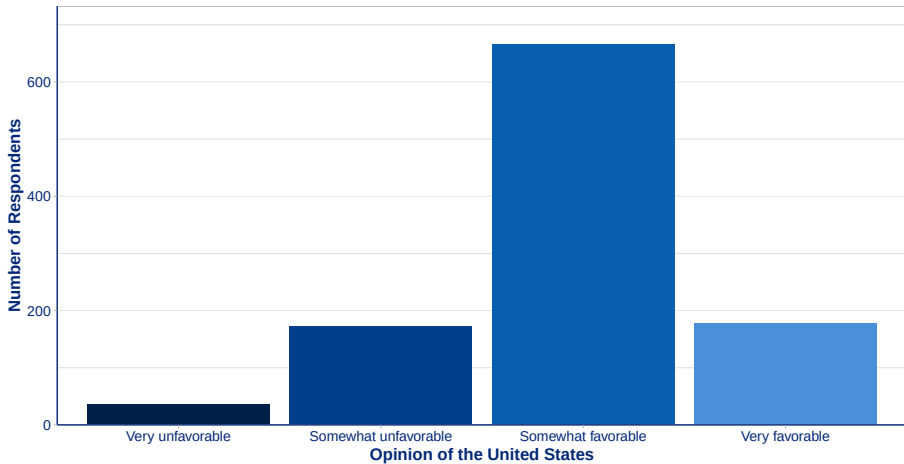
Source: Latinobarómetro 2023 (During Lula's Administration)

Questions:

- Presidential approval
- U.S. and China favorability
- Political and economic relations with U.S. and China
- Great power preference
- Vote intention / party alignment

General Views Towards the United States

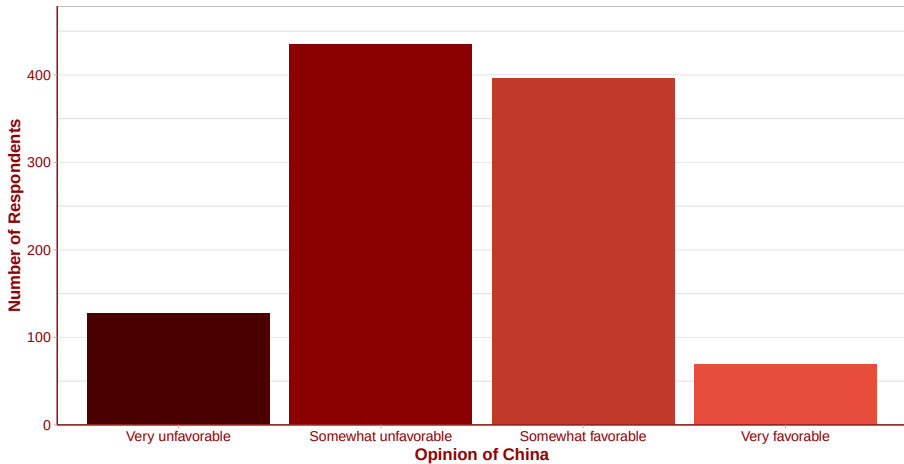
Brazilian Opinion of the United States



Source: Latinobarómetro 2023

General Views Towards China

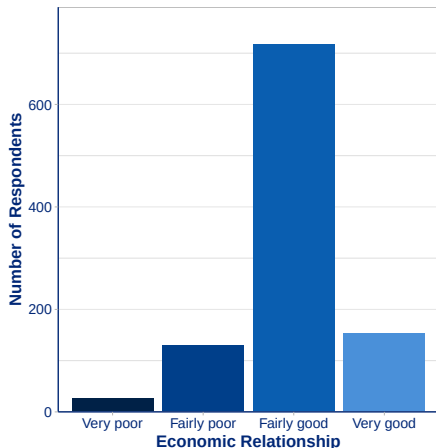
Brazilian Opinion of China



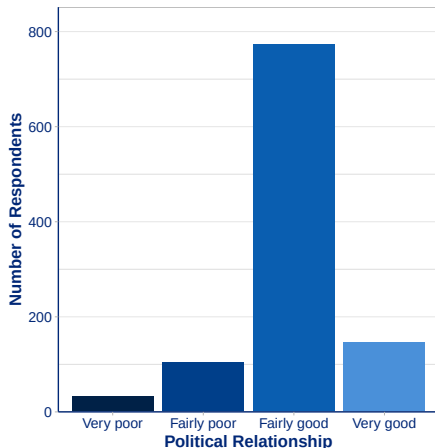
Source: Latinobarómetro 2023

Economic and Political Relations Towards the U.S.

View on Economic and Political Relationship with the United States



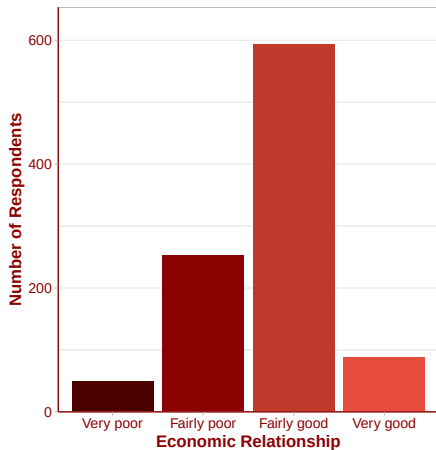
Source: Latinobarómetro 2023



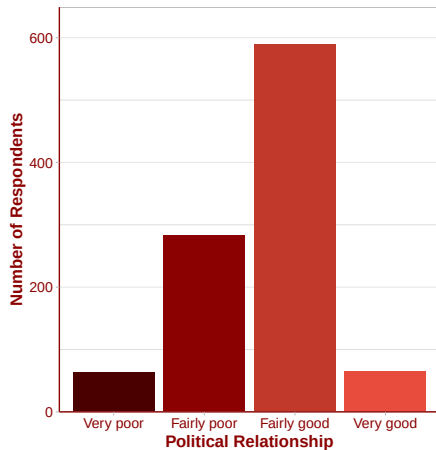
Source: Latinobarómetro 2023

Economic and Political Relations Towards China

View on Economic and Political Relationship with China



Source: Latinobarómetro 2023



Source: Latinobarómetro 2023

What are the Takeaways from These Graphs so far?

Based on the plots analyzing favorability between the Great Powers, it seems that Brazilians tend to have a somewhat favorable view of the United States without accounting for partisanship.

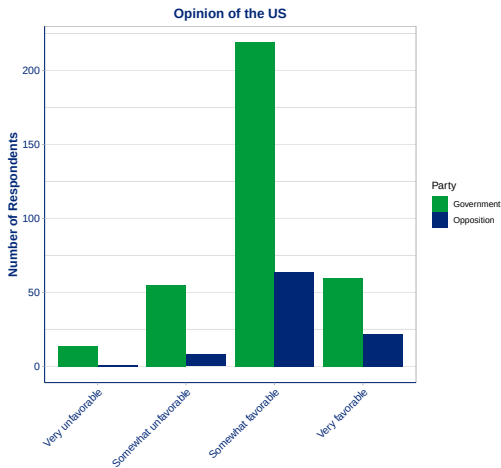
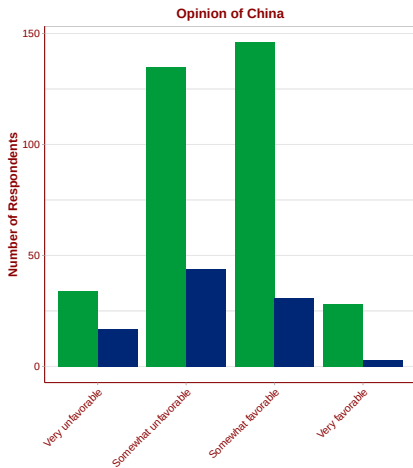
In contrast, when considering China, Brazilians tend to have a more unfavorable view than with the United States, but there is still some level of favorability towards the country as well.

In matters of political and economic relationships, there are two takeaways:

- Respondents tend to correlate political and economic relationships, making their answers fairly similar on both categories
- Most respondents have the impression that political and economic relationships with both countries are fairly good

What happens when we account for partisanship?

Partisanship and Foreign Policy Preferences in Brazil



Source: Latinobarómetro 2023

Takeaways when Considering Partisanship

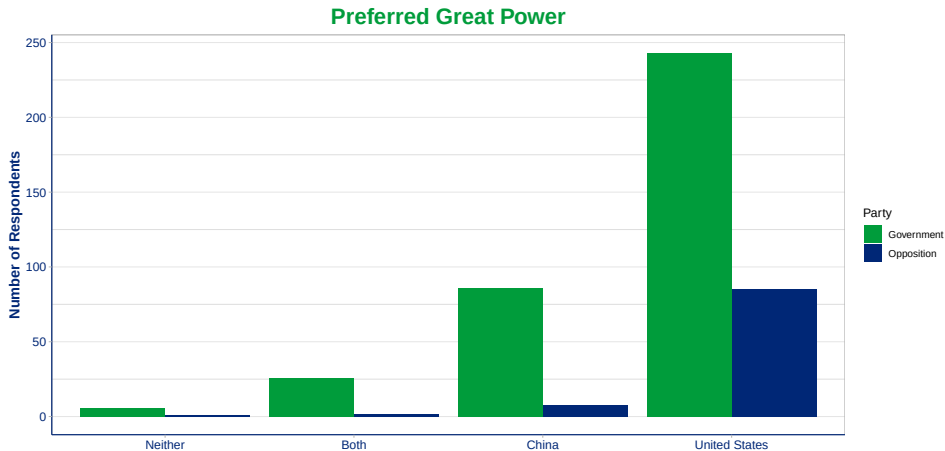
What do Different Voters Think of the Great Powers?

- Supporters of the Government Party (PT) have a slightly more favorable view of the United States than China
 - They also have a more unfavorable view of China than the opposition
- In proportion, government supporters have a similar level of support for both powers, but China has more respondents when accounting for an unfavorable opinion than the U.S.
- The opposition party clearly has a more positive view of the U.S, proportionally
 - In relation to China, there is some level of support, but there is a higher number of respondents with an unfavorable view of this great power

Proportionally, the highest difference is that the supporters of the government have a higher level of favorability to China than the opposition.

What happens when respondents are forced to choose a power for Brazil to align with?

Should Brazil Get Closer to China or the US?



Who do Brazilians Choose to Align with?

Align with the United States!

- When accounting for partisanship, both sets of respondents proportionally favored the United States before China
 - Government supporters had more respondents favoring China, but still a majority choosing the United States over China

Conclusion

- The overview indicated that Brazilians generally have favorable views of the United States and China, but more unfavorable views of China than the United States
- Considering partisanship, voters generally preferred an alignment with the United States before China, if they had to choose, but there were some differences among parties:

Answer to initial Research Question:

Partisanship is correlated with Brazilian's views on foreign policy attitudes. Opposition voters consistently favored alignment with the U.S, while government supporters showed relatively more openness to China

What to Expect of Brazil in the Future?

How is this relevant now?

- Given the importance of foreign policy, the upcoming presidential elections in **October 2026** will be crucial for determining Brazil's future internationally.
- **Lula's reelection** could determine a deepening alliance with China and a gradual shift of the balance of power in China's favor
- A victory from the opposition could result in a deepening alliance with the United States, which would maintain the U.S's hegemony in the Western Hemisphere
- Either outcome will have serious consequences not only for Brazil, but also to the broader **geopolitical competition** between the U.S and China in Latin America